

Nixon vs. Kennedy: A Nation Divided. A Man Invented.



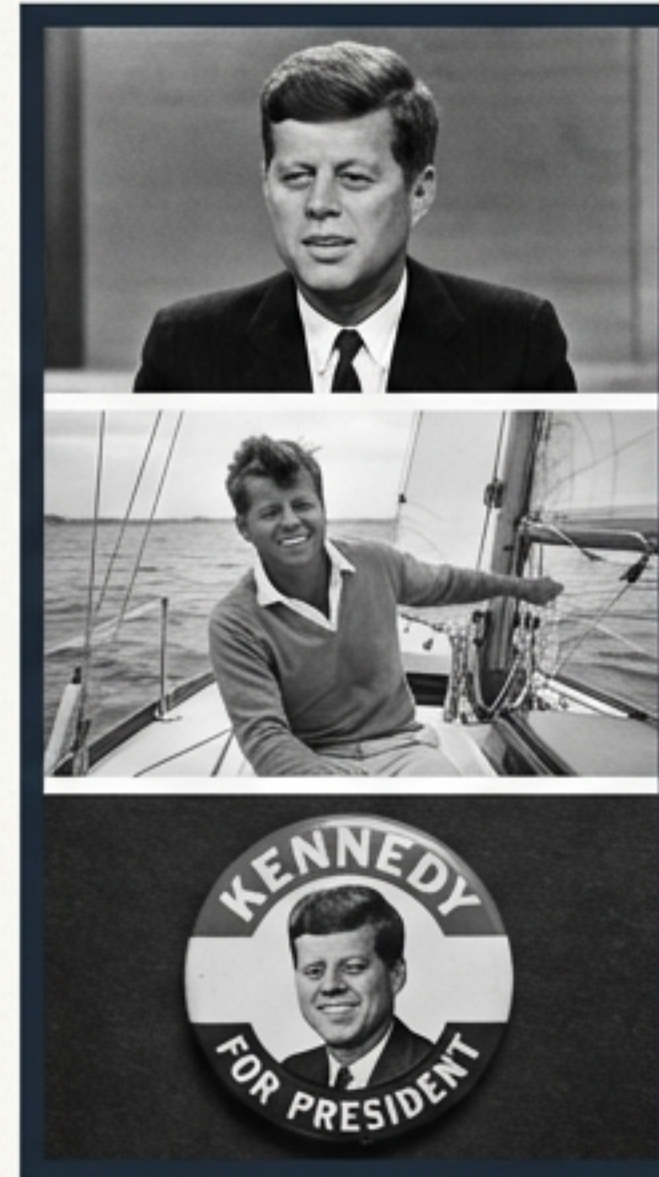
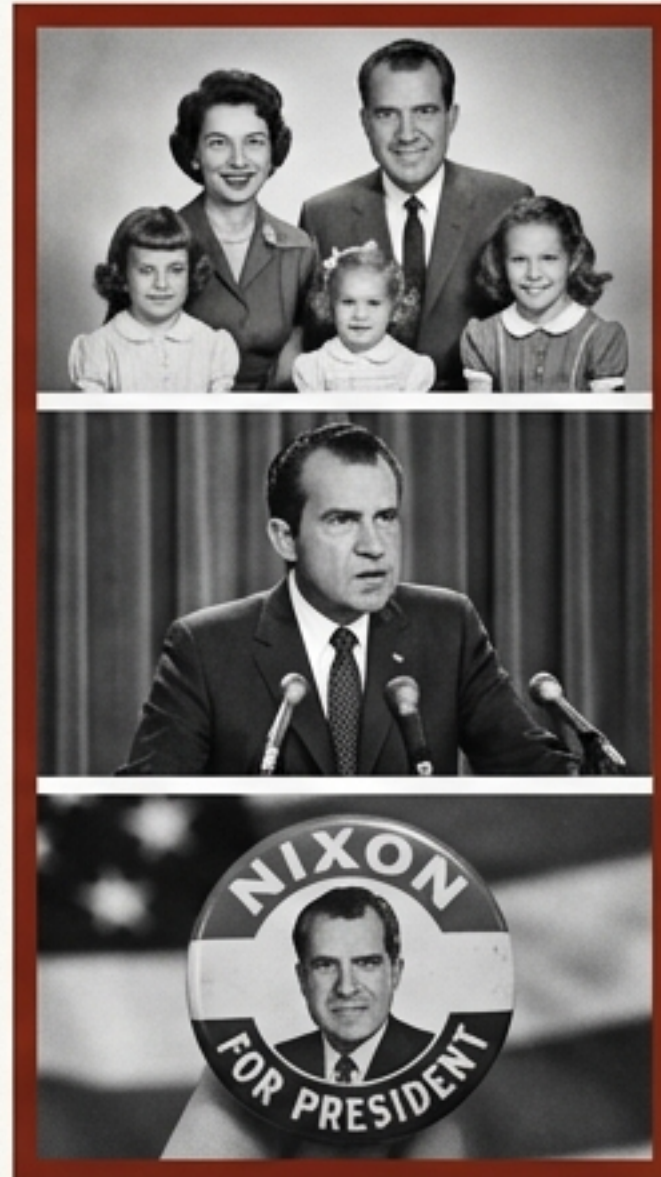
In the fall of 1960, America was choosing its identity. At the advertising agency Sterling Cooper, the man who sold America its image was hiding the fact that his own was a lie. This is the story of how a national election became the backdrop for the total unraveling and revelation of a stolen life.

The 1960 Election: A Battle for America's Image

The 1960 U.S. Presidential Election was more than a political contest; it was a referendum on the American identity.

Nixon:

The established, conservative past. The Vice President under Eisenhower.



Kennedy:

The aspirational, charismatic future.

The first televised debate showcased the power of image over substance.

This national grapple with identity provides the grand stage for the personal crises within Sterling Cooper.

Inside Sterling Cooper, A World of Tailored Suits and Stale Air



- **A Male-Dominated World:** The office culture is defined by widespread drinking and smoking and strict gender roles.
- **The Uniform of Power:** Male executives wear meticulously tailored suits (navy or gray) and skinny ties, symbols of their power and money.
- **Political Lines Drawn:** The agency's old guard, represented by Bert Cooper's Republican affiliation, stands in contrast to the emerging cultural shifts of the 1960s.

Don Draper: The Architect of Illusion



At the center of this world is **Don Draper**, Sterling Cooper's creative genius.

He sells products by selling aspirations. He understands that desire is rooted in the promise of a different, better identity.

But his talent is not just professional. It is the core of his survival. The entire architecture of his life is the greatest campaign he has ever run.

The Lie at the Center of Everything

DON DRAPER IS RICHARD WHITMAN.

- During the Korean War, Richard 'Dick' Whitman assumed the identity of his commanding officer, Lieutenant Donald Draper, after the officer was killed in an explosion.
- This act allowed Whitman to desert the army and escape a traumatic, impoverished past.
- His entire successful and prestigious life is built on this single act of deception and a stolen identity.

An Existence Built on a Stolen Foundation

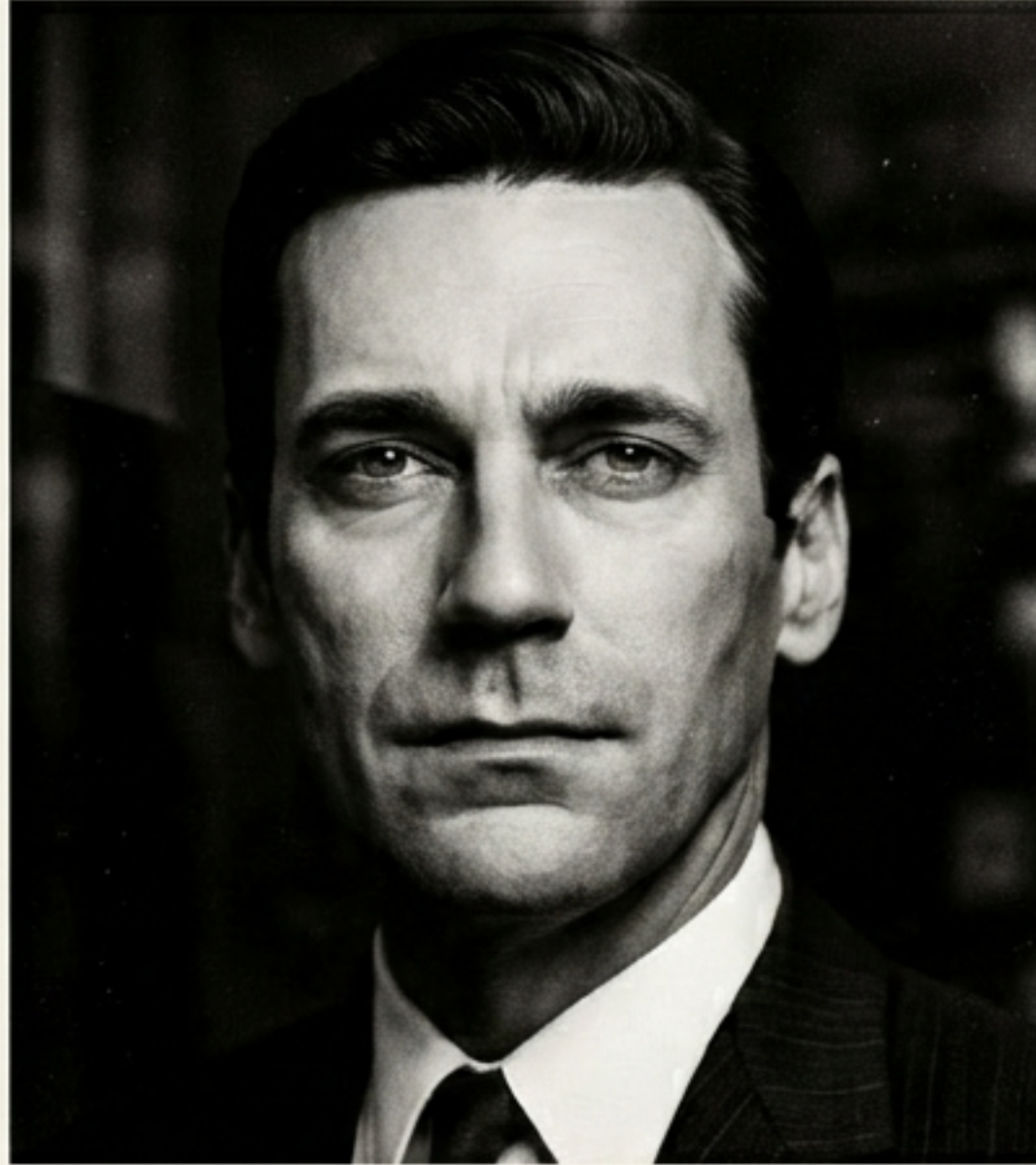


Don Draper's entire existence is predicated on maintaining this illusion of control.

The stolen identity is not just a name; it is an escape from the man he was and a constant, private performance.

Every success, every relationship, and every moment of his life is built upon this fundamental fraud, creating a profound and inescapable isolation.

The Ripple Effect: Everyone is Performing an Identity



Don's lie is the most extreme, but he is not the only one at Sterling Cooper wrestling with a manufactured self. The theme of identity—its creation, its performance, and its burdens—defines the journeys of the women in his life.

Peggy Olson is Forging an Identity



From Secretary to Copywriter:

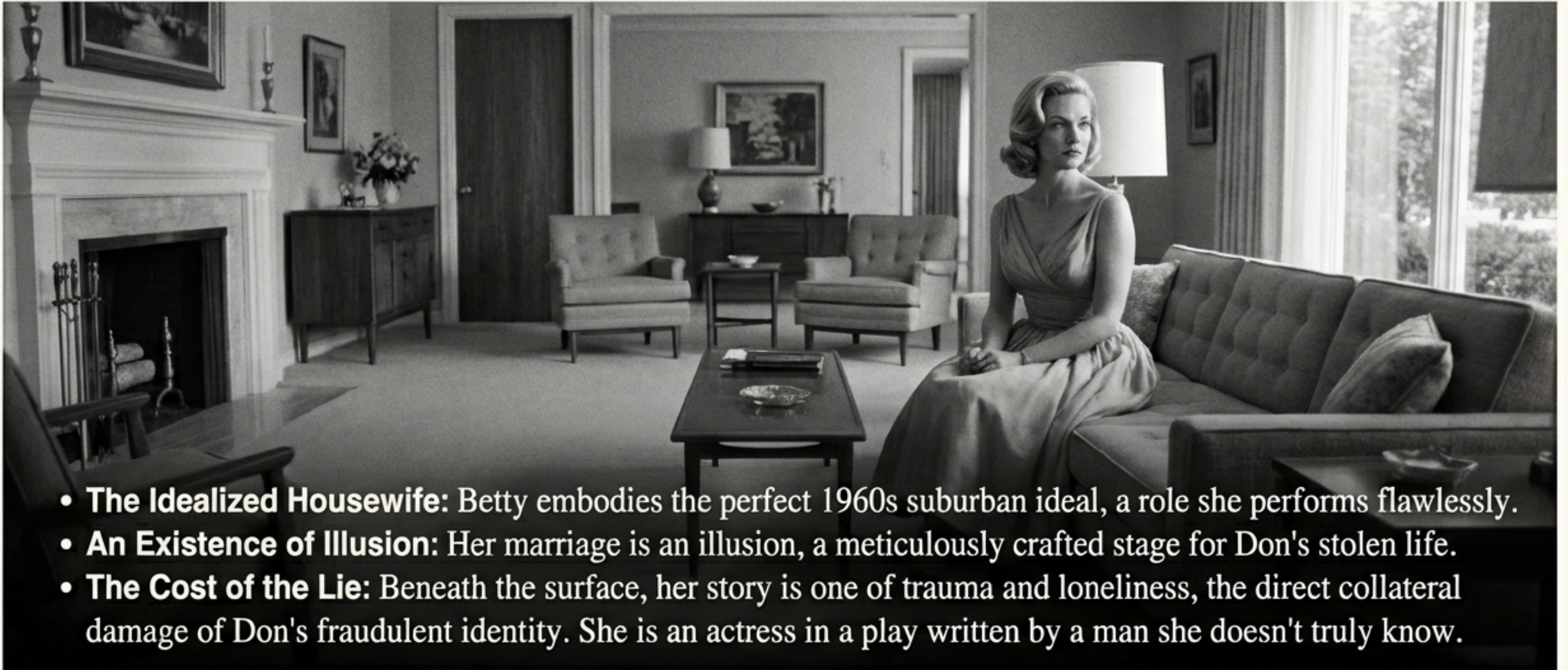
- Peggy is on a narrative arc from a naive secretary to an aspiring copywriter, actively rejecting the expected path of marriage and motherhood.

A Self-Made Woman:

- Her humble and conservative outfits reflect her lower status, but also her focus on creative and business aspirations over conforming to feminine ideals.

The Opposite of Don: Where Don stole an identity, Peggy is building one. Her journey is one of authentic creation in the face of immense social pressure.

Betty Draper is Trapped in an Identity



- **The Idealized Housewife:** Betty embodies the perfect 1960s suburban ideal, a role she performs flawlessly.
- **An Existence of Illusion:** Her marriage is an illusion, a meticulously crafted stage for Don's stolen life.
- **The Cost of the Lie:** Beneath the surface, her story is one of trauma and loneliness, the direct collateral damage of Don's fraudulent identity. She is an actress in a play written by a man she doesn't truly know.

Three Lives, Three Approaches to the Self



Identity: Stolen

An escape from the past built on deception. A performance of confident masculinity that requires constant vigilance and creates total isolation.



Identity: Forged

An authentic creation of a new, professional self. A rejection of prescribed roles in pursuit of personal and creative ambition.



Identity: Illusory

An imposed role within someone else's lie. A performance of domestic perfection that masks deep personal trauma and loneliness.

The Great Illusion of Control



The choice between Nixon and Kennedy was a nation attempting to control its destiny, to choose its future self.

In “Nixon vs. Kennedy,” this political act serves as a grand metaphor for the characters’ desperate attempts to control their own identities.

From Don’s stolen past to Peggy’s forged future and Betty’s illusory present, the episode argues that the self is the most complex product one can ever create—or sell.

The Last Note: A Carousel That Never Moves Forward



The episode ends with the song “The Carousel” by David Carbonara.

The choice is a piece of storytelling genius. **A carousel is a beautiful, nostalgic illusion. It spins in a perfect, repeating circle, creating the feeling of movement while ultimately going nowhere.**

It is the perfect musical metaphor for **Don Draper**: a man trapped in a beautiful, fabricated life, perpetually in motion but never able to escape the past he is running from.

